

## The Extortionist

One day a brahmin presented himself at the court of the king of Gujarat and made **obeisance** to him.

"What brings you here, good man?" asked the **monarch**.

"**Poverty**," replied the man. "I cannot feed my family."

The king gave him a note and asked him to present it to his **treasurer**.

On reading the note, the treasurer gave him a rupee. It was enough to feed a family for a day. So every morning he would present himself at the palace and the king would give him a note to his treasurer.

One day the brahmin was **accosted** by the king's **masseur**.

"You must've seen me pressing His Majesty's legs," said the masseur.

"I have," said the brahmin.

"It is because I keep him in a good mood that he is so generous to you," said the masseur. "I have great influence here. One word from me and you could lose your pension! If you don't want that to happen you must give me four annas as commission every day."

"I cannot give you anything," said the brahmin and walked away.

The masseur **waylaid** him a number of times after that and each time his manner became more and more threatening. But the brahmin refused to give him anything.

One day he accosted the brahmin outside the palace gates.

"I have bad news," he said. "The king is upset with you."

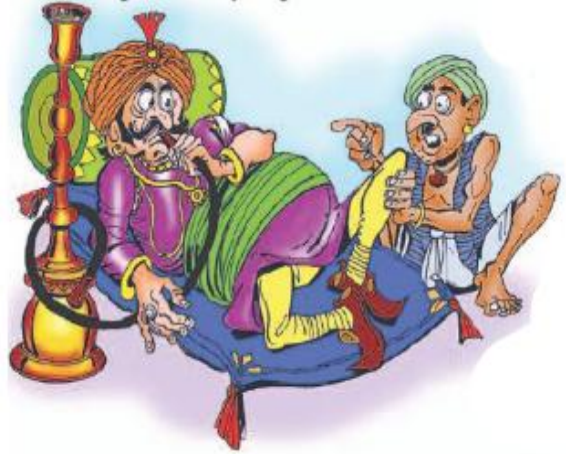
"Upset with me?" said the brahmin, **alarmed**. "Why?"

"He says your breath smells **foul**. Better cover your mouth and nose with a scarf when you go in to see him."

The brahmin thanked him for his warning and went in search of a scarf. The masseur on his part, hurried to the king's chamber before the brahmin and began to massage his legs.

"Some people are so **ungrateful**," he **muttered**, as if under his breath.

"Whom are you talking about?" asked the king.



"The brahmin to whom you give a rupee each day. I met him just now and he was arranging a scarf to cover his mouth and nose."

"Why?" asked the king.

"He says... he says... no, I cannot tell you, Your Majesty..."

"Tell me!" commanded the king.

"He says you have bad breath."

The king showed no emotion when the brahmin came in some time later with a scarf covering his nose and mouth. As usual, he gave him a note to his treasurer.

The masseur was surprised. He had expected the king to **drive** the man away and then he could try to take the pension again. But things had taken an **ominous** turn. One day the king happened to ask the brahmin why he was covering his face and then **the cat would be out of the bag!**

The masseur excused himself and hurried after the brahmin to warn him never to disclose why he was covering his mouth.

The brahmin was touched that he should take so much interest in his welfare. "Now I regret I did not give you your commission," he said. "Here, take the whole rupee," and he handed him the note to the treasurer.

The masseur, **overjoyed**, rushed to the treasurer with the note. But instead of being handed a coin he was **manacled** by the guards.

"What's this!" cried the **bewildered** man. "Why am I being **manhandled** in this fashion?!"

"King's orders," explained the treasurer. "The coded message says I have to **sew up** the mouth of the bearer of the note."

The masseur had to reveal everything to save himself — which he managed to do but he was **banished** from the city. As for the brahmin he continued to receive a rupee each day for the rest of his life.

### Vocabulary

1. **The extortionist** (noun) – blackmailer, racketeer, coercer, intimidator, shakedown artist उगाही करने वाला/ब्लैकमेलर
2. **Obeisance** (noun) – bow, reverence, homage, genuflection, prostration प्रणाम/श्रद्धा-नम्रता
3. **Monarch** (noun) – king, sovereign, ruler, potentate, crowned head सम्राट/राजा
4. **Poverty** (noun) – destitution, penury, indigence, impecuniosity, want गरीबी/दरिद्रता
5. **Treasurer** (noun) – bursar, finance officer, paymaster, cashier, quaestor कोषाध्यक्ष
6. **Accost** (verb) – confront, approach, waylay, hail, buttonhole रोककर बात करना/घेरना
7. **Masseur** (noun) – massage therapist, bodyworker, masseuse (female), spa therapist, rubber (dated) मालिश करने वाला
8. **Waylaid** (verb) – ambush, intercept, accost, hold up, bushwhack घात लगाकर रोकना/रास्ता रोकना
9. **Alarm** (verb) – frighten, startle, unsettle, panic, dismay घबरा देना/चिंतित करना
10. **Smell foul** (phrase) – reek, stink, smell bad, stink to high heaven, have halitosis दुर्गंध आना/बदबू आना
11. **Ungrateful** (adjective) – thankless, unappreciative, ungracious, unthankful, churlish अकृतज्ञ/एहसान-फरामोश
12. **Mutter** (verb) – murmur, mumble, grumble, whisper, growl बड़बड़ाना/धीमे स्वर में कहना
13. **Drive** (verb) – expel, oust, chase away, repel, dismiss भगा देना/दूर करना
14. **Ominous** (adjective) – foreboding, sinister, menacing, inauspicious, portentous अपशकुनी/अशुभ संकेत वाला
15. **The cat would be out of the bag** (phrase) – the secret would be out, be revealed, be exposed, come to light, be made public राज़ फ़ाश हो जाएगा/भेद खुल जाएगा
16. **Overjoy** (verb) – delight, elate, exhilarate, enrapture, gladden अत्यंत प्रसन्न करना/हर्षित करना
17. **Manacle** (verb) – handcuff, shackle, fetter, chain, restrain हथकड़ी/बेड़ियाँ डालना
18. **Bewilder** (verb) – confuse, perplex, baffle, befuddle, flummox उलझन में डालना/हैरान करना
19. **Manhandle** (verb) – rough up, mishandle, shove, push around, drag हाथापाई/ज़बरदस्ती करना

20. **Sew up** (phrasal verb) – stitch up, suture, sew shut, stitch closed, sew together सिल देना/टॉके लगाकर बंद करना

21. **Banish** (verb) – exile, expel, deport, oust, ostracize निर्वासित करना/देश-निकाला देना

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